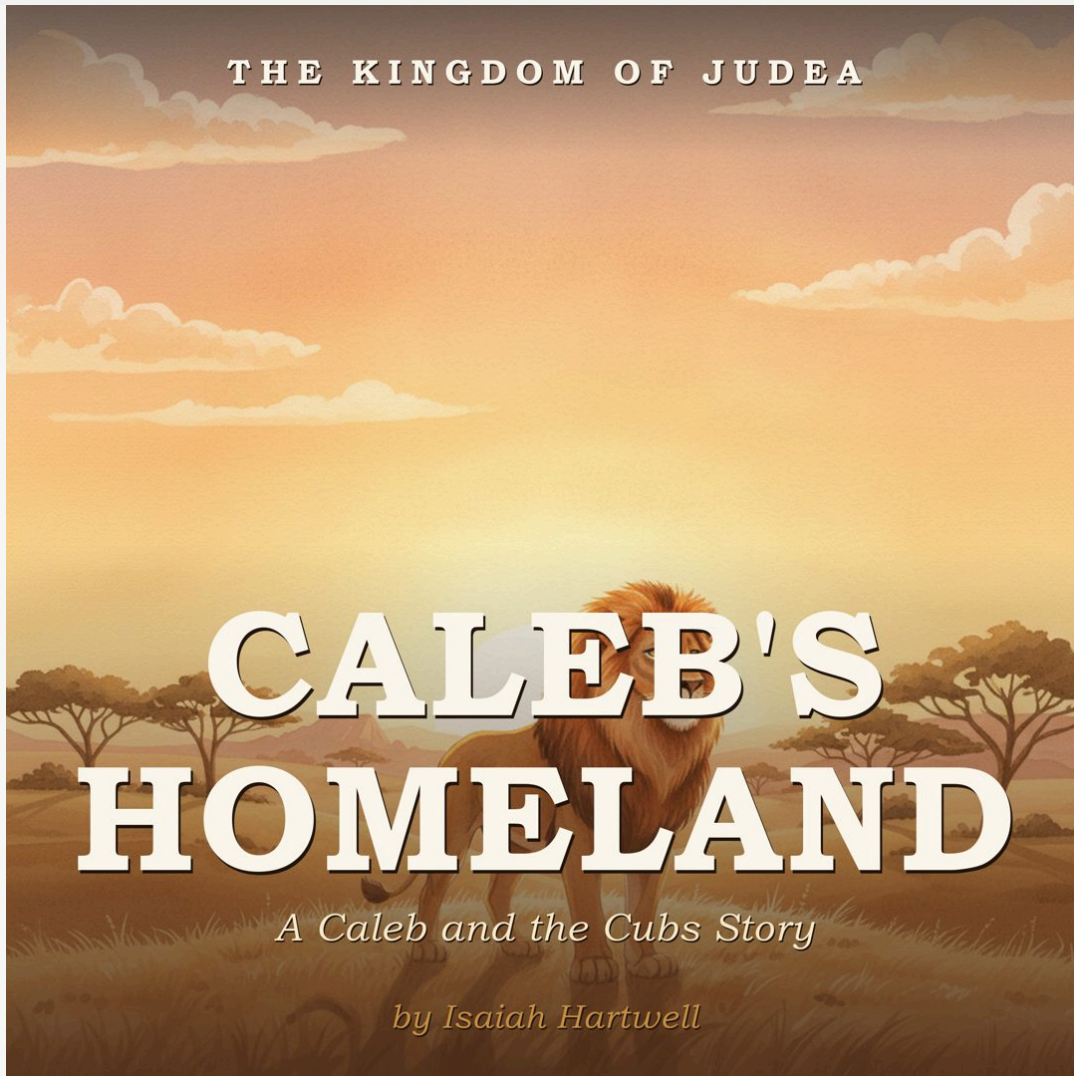




THE KINGDOM OF JUDEA

Caleb's Homeland

Caleb's Homeland

Caleb's Homeland

The Kingdom of Judea · Book One

Made Out of Clay Productions

God's Love Never Fails

by Isaiah Hartwell

For our son, Clayton



The sun came up over Hebron Ridge
the way it always came up —
first on the high stones,
then on the long gold grass,
then on the water hole,
which shone like a moon laid flat.

This was Hebron Ridge.

This was Caleb's land.

This was Hannah's land.

This was the only land their cubs had ever known.

And oh — it was beautiful.



Every morning, Caleb walked the borders of Hebron Ridge.

He was the strongest lion in the pride.

His shoulders were wide.

His paws were quiet.

His full mane caught the wind and held it.

When Caleb passed, the other lions stood a little taller —

not because he asked them to.

Because he was that kind of lion.

The kind whose steady made everyone steady.

He had not always walked the borders alone.

Once, long ago, another lion had walked them beside him.

But that lion had stopped coming,

season by quiet season,

and stayed up near the high stone now —

the one who stands at Korah's side.

Caleb still left room for him on the path.



Hannah sat in the shade with the cubs piled close,
and she hummed while she watched them —
a song her mother had hummed,
and her mother's mother before that.
A song about a God who is always near,
even in the long grass,
even on the dark nights.
She had never taught them the words.
She didn't need to. Not yet.
The cubs heard the song every single day.
They didn't know they were learning it.
That's how the best songs get in.



Ezra was the oldest cub.
His mane was just coming in —
not deep and full like his father's,
just enough to show the lion he was going to be.
He did not race the other cubs.
He watched things.
He could tell which way the herds would turn
by the way the grass tipped.
He could tell which night would be cold
by the color of the sky at dusk.
Hannah called him my careful one.
Caleb just called him son,
and squeezed his shoulder when he passed —
which, for Ezra, was better.



Leah was the older daughter, quick and sure.
Every morning she practiced her stance by the water.
She was kind the way the strong ones are kind —
 never loud about it.
You felt it in the way she set her paw down
 beside somebody smaller,
 so they wouldn't be afraid.
She wore a red flower behind one ear
 because she felt like it.
Soon every young lioness in the pride wore one too.
But lately, Leah would not go near the high stone.
 There was a cub up there —
an older cub from the high stone, the one whose father stayed close to Korah —
 who had said cruel things to her last week —
 the kind of words that stick,
 and make a young lion go quiet.
Hannah saw it in her face.
Hannah did not push.
Hannah waited, the way mothers wait —
with the door of her heart propped open.



Asher was the younger son.
No mane yet — he was too young for a mane —
but he had a roar he was working on.
He tried it that morning.
Big breath. Chest out. Ready —
The roar came out like a sneeze.
Tirzah laughed and laughed.
Asher took another breath and tried again.
A little better. Not much.
"Getting closer," he said.
And he believed it, too.
That was the thing about Asher.
He always believed it.



Tirzah was the youngest of them all,
small and pale as morning cream,
with one pale-pink flower behind one ear
because Asher had picked it for her.

She didn't say much.

She saw everything.

She saw when Mama's shoulders went tight.

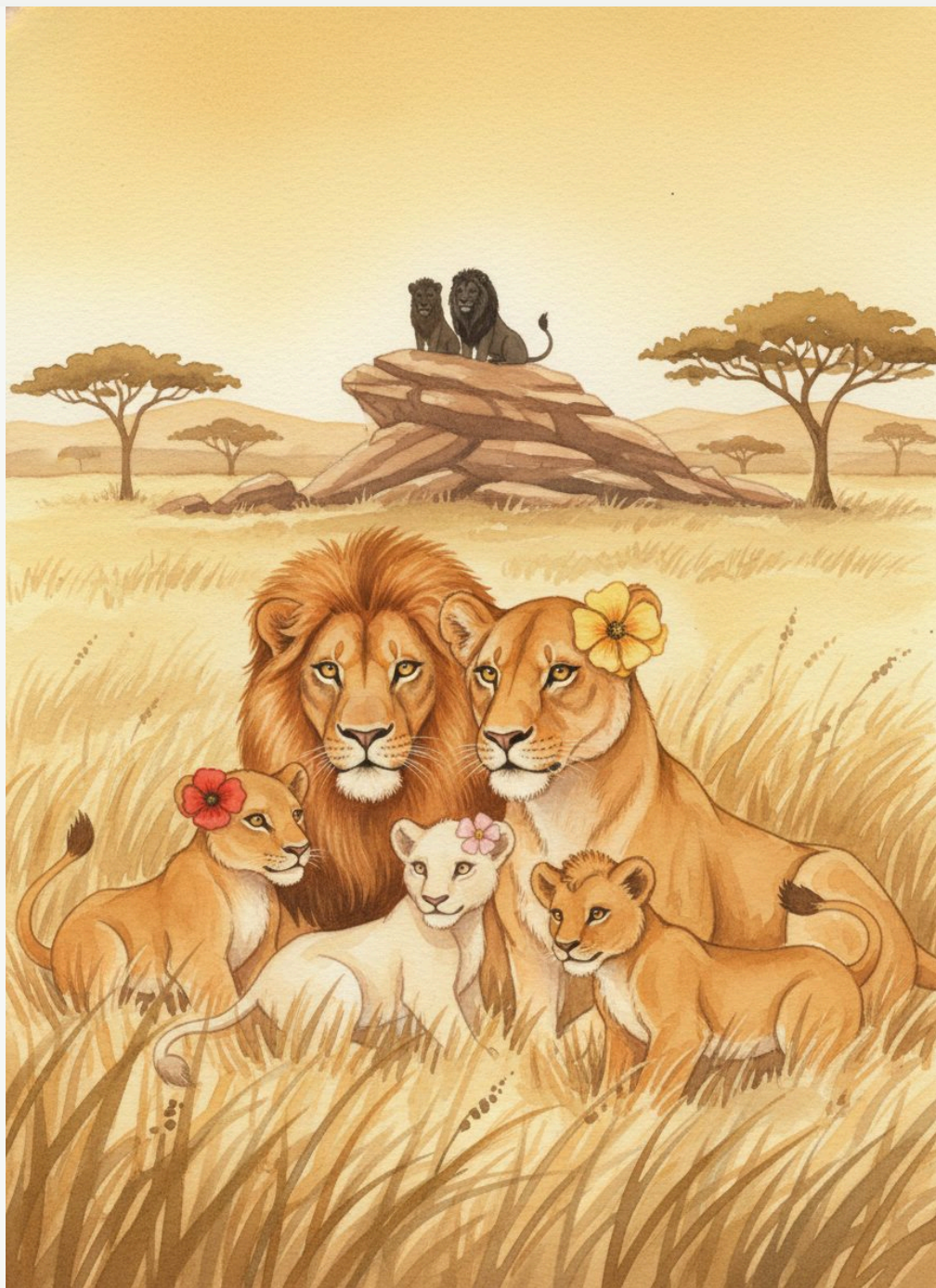
She saw when Ezra needed to be left alone.

She saw when Asher needed someone to laugh.

She saw that Leah would not look at the high stone
anymore.

Tirzah was small.

Her love was not.



Nearly all the pride loved Caleb's family.
When Caleb walked through the long grass,
the old lions nodded.
When Hannah passed,
mothers lifted their cubs a little higher to see her.
When Asher tried his roar,
even the grandfathers laughed —
warm, kind, that-was-me-once laughs.
But not all of them.
Up on the high stone, where the leader watched the pride,
two lions watched Caleb's family
and did not smile.
One was old, with grey threaded through his dark mane.
One was younger, with a mane like deep shadow —
darker than Caleb's, without one thread of grey —
standing half a step behind the old one,
where he always stood.
They did not nod.
They did not wave.
They watched.



The old lion was named Korah,
and he had been a great leader once.
Long ago, he had stood for the pride
the way Caleb stood now —
patient and strong,
the last to eat,
the first to the border.
But years are like rivers.
They carve.
Somewhere in all those years,
something in Korah had bent toward himself.
His pride grew bigger than his heart.
More land. More food. More to rule.
More, and more, and more —
and never once enough.
The lion at his side had stayed through all of it.
He had become Korah's voice when Korah didn't care to speak —
sharper than Korah,
colder than Korah,
and very, very loyal.
The pride still followed them both.
But more and more, quietly, it watched Caleb.
Korah noticed.



One golden afternoon, Korah called Caleb to the foot of the high
stone.

Korah's older son did not greet him.

He never did anymore.

"There is a small pride past our southern border," Korah said.

"They are weak. We are strong.

Tonight, we take their land."

The lion at his side said nothing.

He had already nodded — once, slow —

before Korah even spoke.

Caleb looked at the old lion for a long, long time.

Then he said one word.

"No."

The grass went still between them.

Even the wind held its breath.



"They have done nothing to us," Caleb said.

"They have cubs. They have mothers.

They have a home, the same as ours.

Taking it would not make us strong.

It would only make us thieves

with a strong story.

Claws down. Hearts up.

That is how my family lives.

I will not be part of it."

Korah's eyes went small and dark.

Korah's older son spoke at last,

in a voice with thorns in it.

"A pride survives by strength, Caleb. Not songs."

Caleb did not answer him.

He kept his eyes on Korah,

and waited for what he knew was coming.



Korah stepped close.
"At first light," he said, low,
"you and I fight before the whole pride.
Win, and you lead them.
Lose — and I do not lose —
and you and your family
leave this land forever."
Caleb did not answer.
He turned and walked home through the long gold grass,
past the water hole,
past every border he had walked all his life.
Behind him, on the high stone,
the younger lion smiled.
It was not the kind of smile
that reaches the eyes.



That night, Caleb sat at the mouth of the den, very still.
He could fight Korah.
He could win.
They both knew he could win.
But he kept seeing how it would go.
The pride pulling apart like a storm-split sky —
some following Caleb,
some following the lion with the shadow-dark mane.
Friend against friend.
Brothers facing brothers.
Mothers losing sons.
A win like that is just a slower way to lose.
Gentle is strong.
He had taught the cubs that.
Tonight he would have to live it.
He looked in at his cubs, asleep in a heap —
Ezra. Leah. Asher. Tirzah.
Breathing easy.
Trusting the night to him.
He thought of Leah —
of the cruel words the older cub had said to her last week,
the ones that had made her go quiet —
and of how some hurts come from staying too long
in the wrong shadow.
"Hannah," he said. "I cannot fight him."
Hannah had been beside him the whole time.
She put her paw on his.
"Then we walk," she said.
"And we trust the God of the song."



That night, Hannah gathered the cubs in close,
and for the first time, she gave them the words —
the words inside the song
she had hummed over them all their lives.

Three small lines, soft as breath:

God is near.

God is here.

God's love never fails.

Ezra mouthed it, testing each word the way he tested everything.

Leah stared at the ground — then said it anyway.

Asher said it loud, and tried to roar it after.

Tirzah tucked it into the small place inside her
where she kept the things she loved most.

The song had been her mother's,
and her mother's mother's before that.

Now it was theirs.

It was going to have to be.



At first light, Caleb did not go to the high stone.
He went to the den,
and woke his cubs gently, one by one —
Ezra first, then Leah, then Asher, then Tirzah.
He did not say we lost.
He did not say be afraid.
He said:
"Stand tall.
We walk together.
We walk where God wants us to walk.
His will be done."
Hannah began to hum.
And the family — six golden lions, six quiet hearts —
walked out of Hebron Ridge,
out of the only home the cubs had ever known,
into a land that did not have a name yet.
Leah walked out with her head high.
She did not look back at the high stone —
not once.
As they passed beneath it,
a claw slipped out of the shadow
and caught Caleb across the shoulder.
He did not stop.
He did not answer it.
He kept walking — claws down, hearts up —
and carried the hurt out with him.
Behind them, the sun rose on the high stone,
where the younger lion stood watching them go.
He did not call out.
He did not move.
And all through the long gold grass,
the rest of the pride watched in silence —
not one of them daring
to say goodbye out loud.
In front of them lay a long, long walk.
But God was near.
God was here.
And God's love never fails.
